

Kanban: A Simple Way to Manage Projects

In the first part of this series of articles on open source project management tools, we looked at desktop tools like MS Project. Part 2 discussed project servers like MS Project Server. In Part 3 we looked at agile/Scrum software project management tools. In this fourth and final part, we will see how Kanban helps in managing projects.



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Management of an event — a VIP visit to your factory, relocation of your office or an open house — requires the assignment of tasks to different people, keeping an eye on work in progress and making sure nothing slips through the cracks. These projects do not warrant going through a full-fledged project management routine. A simple tool like Kanban that is easy to set up, and easy to access and work with for everyone in the team is the need of the day.

If the entire team works in one location, these projects can be run using sticky notes moved across a series of status columns on a whiteboard. Everyone can see at a glance who is working on what, if any essential tasks are missing, and whether the team is making good progress towards meeting the deadlines.

Team members can choose tasks from the 'To Do' column and add their names to the sticky note. Or the team leader or coordinator can assign tasks

to them. When the persons responsible start the tasks, they move the sticky note into the 'Doing' column. When they are done, the note is put in the 'Done' column and a new task is chosen by the team members. If the process requires other status columns such as 'In Verification' or 'Blocked', they can be added, as needed.

But if some of the team members are working in different locations or from home, or there are outside vendors or contractors involved, it